MONKEY-TAILED SKINK

Corucia zebrata

Think About This

If you stayed with your family for years, what would you want them to teach you?

What can it see, hear, or feel?

Its flickering tongue tastes the air, its eyes see in dim light, and it senses movement on branches.

Where does it live — and why?

It lives high in island forest trees, where its gripping tail holds on as it reaches for leaves.

How does it send messages?

It hisses as a warning, bites if ignored, and rubs scent on branches its family group shares.

What does it do when something changes?

When threatened, it grips tight with its tail, turns sideways, and hisses at the approaching danger.

How does it learn?

Young skinks stay in the family group for months, and adults protect them as they learn the trees.

How does it have babies?

A mother carries one big baby inside her body and gives birth live — unusual for a lizard.

What are its limits?

It needs special forest plants, so when trees are cut, both its food and its home disappear.

What does this teach us?

A lizard that lives in a family group teaches us that reptiles can cooperate too.